

FORMAL COMPLAINT

Commission on Judicial Performance

455 Golden Gate Avenue, Suite 14400
San Francisco, CA 94102

Complainant: Claudia Stephan Sandoval Molina

Mother of Aostin Aparicio, Eirah Castaneda, Athena Castaneda, and Elleonore Castaneda
[Address] · [Phone] · [Email]

Judge Subject to Complaint: Hon. Steven A. Mapes, Superior Court of California, County of San Bernardino,
Department J-6

Case Numbers: J290945-47, J294367; Appeal No. E080818

Date: August 2026

I. PURPOSE AND SCOPE

The undersigned submits this complaint against Judge Steven A. Mapes based on three specific charges of judicial misconduct, supported by verifiable documentary evidence.

This complaint does not seek reversal of any court order. The undersigned acknowledges that disagreement with a judicial decision, standing alone, does not constitute misconduct. This complaint alleges a pattern of conduct that, if confirmed, would violate the Canons of the California Code of Judicial Ethics.

Appeal No. E080818 is currently pending. The Commission is requested to proceed in parallel, as the charges relate to ethical conduct, not legal errors reviewable on appeal, and there is documented risk of death to four minors.

II. URGENCY

Athena and Elleonore Castaneda suffer from Familial Expansile Osteolysis (FEO) (TNFRSF11A gene mutation), a life-threatening genetic condition if not properly treated, documented with symptoms across five generations. Aostin and Eirah have not been evaluated. The undersigned does not know the current whereabouts of her biological children, or is unsure whether the minors remain in the location where she last saw them. Referral to competent authorities is requested.

III. CHARGE 1: DOCUMENTED PREJUDGMENT

Fact: At the first detention hearing (10/20/2021), Judge Mapes stated: *"I will tell Mom, it is possible she won't get services and **we will terminate parental rights**. Make sure appears and cooperates and all of that good stuff."* (Vol. 1, p. 10). At the same hearing, when imposing a temporary detriment finding against the mother regarding minor Aostin: *"For Aostin, I do agree with County Counsel."* In response to the defense objection (*"That is over our objection"*): *"I know. Overruled."* (Vol. 1, p. 12).

Analysis: A detention hearing evaluates prima facie risk and orders reunification services (WIC § 300 et seq.). Termination of parental rights (TPR) is the final step, requiring clear and convincing evidence and due process protections. Announcing TPR at the first hearing, before any evidence has been presented, constitutes prejudgment.